

Yadav in Kannauj, while other candidates emerged victorious in Etawah, Bulandshahr, Firozabad and Etah. With the support of Kurmis and other most backward castes, Mulayam's men won in Mirzapur, Fatehpur, Banda and some other places. It was Mulayam-Amar combine, with the support of the OBCs, that shattered dreams of rebel Azam Khan by paving the way Jayaprada's victory. The OBC mobilisation also speaks of Mulayam's perfection in the fieldcraft and sensing the pulse of the people.

But the loss of the Muslims would continue to haunt Mulayam and should concern him equally if his party has to remain a formidable player in the state. It was the first time that 13 MPs, mostly Muslims, quit the Samajwadi Party in the last two years. Moreover, two new political outfits dominated by the Muslims—Ulema Council and the Peace Party—also posed a serious threat to the SP's support base. Muslims turned against the SP and BSP also because they realised that it was only the Congress that could prevent the march of the BJP at the national level.

The SP chief had realised early that in 2009 he was not going to repeat his 2004 performance of retaining 35 seats. Even though he did not project himself, like his counterpart Mayawati, as a prime ministerial candidate, he did say "no government could be formed at Centre without support of the Samajwadi Party". But the results clearly show that Mulayam is neither king nor kingmaker and is at best a state-level leader.

by Subhash Misra

M. KARUNANIDHI

Patriarch's Day

There have been so many political obituaries written for M. Karunanidhi during the last few years that even the Tamil Nadu chief minister would be hard put to keep count. But like Mark Twain said on reading his own obituary, the DMK supremo has responded each time by proving that the "reports of (his) death are greatly exaggerated". Pundits and TV prophets have got it terribly wrong once again—the DMK is now seen to be more alive today than at any time in the past. By again winning a substantial number of seats, the DMK and its alliance partner, the Congress, have stood conventional state politics on its head. For one, voters in Tamil Nadu are as vengeful as they are emotional and seldom vote for incumbents. Secondly, they are known to pack the whole lot of them off, lock, stock and barrel. Five years ago, Jayalalithaa was at the receiving end when voters gave all 39 seats to the DMK-Congress alliance. This time, psephologists were so confident that voters would turn their ire on the alliance that J. Jayalalithaa believed them when they said Karunanidhi was ailing, that his government reeked of corruption, that his sons Stalin and Azhagiri don't have their father's



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charisma to pull in the votes. Her belief in them was so complete that she even announced plans to shift temporarily to Delhi to play her role as a kingmaker and then kept everyone who was desperate for her support guessing by keeping her cards close to her bosom.

Karunanidhi, on the contrary, acted like the patriarch. He swore by the UPA even when the Government refused to do his bidding. Ill-health kept him at home and away from the campaign though a much publicised fast—where he ate nothing between breakfast and lunch—to express solidarity with the Sri Lankan Tamils did help in large measure. As did the images, beamed faithfully by family-owned TV channels that showed the ailing 85-year-old being occasionally wheeled to office and more frequently to hospital and back.

When security agencies cited terror threats from Tamil extremists and advised Sonia Gandhi against visiting him in a Chennai hospital, the city was abuzz with rumours of the Congress doubting the Kalaigarnar's ability to deliver and was looking for dividends elsewhere. Jayalalithaa added her own bit, saying that Congress leaders had contacted her. It was left to Sonia and Manmohan Singh to put all rumours to rest by calling on Karunanidhi which was the equivalent of a "death do us part" communique. This election is proof, if indeed it were needed, that in politics, always expect the unexpected. All the more so in Tamil Nadu.

by Ashok Damodaran